

FL-02: The Prompt Ladder

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BASELINE PROMPT

The weak prompt: summarize this book

The AI's output:

The Art of Being Funny: Humor Skills Anyone Can Learn — Summary

Author: Emily Parker

Core thesis: Humor isn't an innate gift some people are born with — it's a learnable skill, built from observation, storytelling, timing, and mindset, that anyone can develop through practice.

The book is organized into four parts plus a bonus chapter, moving from *why* people aren't naturally funny (they've just practiced a skillset) to *how* to build that skillset in daily life.

Part One: Why Some People Seem Naturally Funny Debunks the "born funny" myth, explaining that humor relies on hidden, learnable skills. It covers the psychology of laughter — the brain as a "prediction machine" that rewards surprise and pattern-recognition — plus the foundational skills of observation (noticing everyday absurdities), storytelling (tension, pacing, vivid detail), and timing (the pause, reading the room, not rushing punchlines).

Part Two: Building a Funny Mind Focuses on mental habits: seeing the ordinary world with curiosity, "thinking sideways" or laterally to find unexpected connections, and other exercises for training a mind to spot comedic angles rather than just reacting to them.

Part Three: Turning Humor Into a Skill Gets more tactical — how to actually construct and deliver humor in conversation, why certain jokes land and others fail (trying too hard, over-explaining, predictability), and the importance of being genuine rather than performative. A recurring theme here is that timing and delivery can't rescue a weak idea, and that humor should feel like a natural conversation, not a competition or a test.

Part Four: Living a Life Filled With Laughter Zooms out to the bigger picture — how humor improves resilience, relationships, and how people experience difficult days, ending with the idea that the real goal isn't becoming "the funniest person in the room" but becoming someone whose presence makes life lighter for others.

Bonus Chapter: Fifty Timeless Habits of Naturally Funny People A distilled list of 50 small habits (paying attention, listening fully, laughing at oneself, choosing warmth over sarcasm, appreciating silence, avoiding cruelty, staying curious, etc.) meant to be absorbed gradually rather than all at once.

VERSION 1

Prompt: summarize the book for children and teenagers

Output:

Here's the book in plain, friendly language — no confusing jargon, just the good stuff:

Big idea: Being funny isn't something you're just "born with," like eye color. It's a skill — just like riding a bike or playing basketball. If you practice the right habits, you *will* get funnier. That's really good news, because it means anyone can learn it, including you.

How the book breaks it down:

- 1. Funny people aren't magic — they practice.** The "funniest kid in class" isn't secretly gifted. They've just picked up habits like noticing weird little things, telling stories well, and knowing *when* to say something (timing matters more than people think).
- 2. Your brain actually loves to laugh.** Laughing happens when your brain expects one thing and gets a surprise instead. That's why a joke with an unexpected twist works, and why the same joke told the exact same way twice usually isn't as funny the second time.
- 3. Watch the world like a detective.** Funny people notice small, strange details everyone else walks past — like how weird it is that we say "heads up" when we actually mean "look down." Training yourself to *really* notice things is half of being funny.
- 4. Tell better stories.** Good stories have a little tension (something going a bit wrong), vivid details (so people can picture it), and they don't rush the best part. Funny people are basically just good storytellers.
- 5. Timing is everything.** A pause before the punchline, waiting for the right moment, not talking over people — that's a real skill, not luck.

what changed in the prompt: I added a clearer audience

What improved in the output: The words are simpler and easier for children and teenagers to understand

What still failed: It is not organized well

What would you try to improve: The structure of the output

VERSION 2

Prompt: summarize the book for children and teenagers and ensure you break it into chapters

Output:

Part One: Why Some People Seem Naturally Funny

Chapter 1 – The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nope — nobody's just "born" funny. It's a skill, like drawing or skateboarding. Anyone can learn it with practice.

Chapter 2 – Your Brain Was Built to Laugh Your brain loves surprises. Laughing happens when something unexpected happens — that's the secret behind most jokes.

Chapter 3 – The Superpower of Observation Funny people notice tiny weird details everyone else ignores. Paying close attention to the world is basically comedy training.

Chapter 4 – Every Funny Person Is a Great Storyteller Jokes and stories aren't that different. A little tension, good details, and not rushing the ending make a story (and a joke) land.

Chapter 5 – Timing: The Invisible Skill That Makes Humor Work A well-placed pause can make a joke ten times funnier. Timing isn't luck — it's something you can practice.

Part Two: Building a Funny Mind

Chapter 6 – The Way Funny People See the World Funny people stay curious and treat ordinary things like they're seeing them for the first time.

Chapter 7 – Thinking Sideways: The Secret Behind Creative Humor Instead of the obvious answer, ask "what if?" Connecting two random ideas is where a lot of clever humor comes from.

what changed in the prompt : I added a format

What improved in the output: It summarized per chapter as told

What still failed: It is still not well formatted

What would you try to improve: I will give an example

VERSION 3

Prompt: summarize the book for children and teenagers and ensure you break it into chapters using this format: CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Beign Born Funny Nobody's born funny...

Output:

CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nobody's born funny. It just looks that way because we don't see all the practice behind it. Being funny is a skill, like drawing or skating — you build it over time, not something you're handed at birth.

CHAPTER TWO: Your Brain Was Built to Laugh Your brain is wired to expect certain things, and it loves being pleasantly surprised. That surprise is what makes you laugh. Understanding this "surprise trick" is the secret behind almost every joke.

CHAPTER THREE: The Superpower of Observation Funny people notice weird little details that everyone else walks right past. Training yourself to actually *notice* the world around you is one of the biggest comedy skills there is.

CHAPTER FOUR: Every Funny Person Is a Great Storyteller A funny moment is really just a mini-story. If you build a little tension, add vivid details, and don't rush to the end, your stories (and jokes) will land way better.

CHAPTER FIVE: Timing — The Invisible Skill That Makes Humor Work The exact same joke can bomb or kill depending on when you say it. A well-placed pause can make something ten times funnier. This is a skill you can practice, not something you either have or don't.

what changed in the prompt : I gave an example of the format

What improved in the output: It followed the format I gave it to an extent

What still failed: There is no clear distinction between the topic and the body

What would you try to improve: I will make sure the example is clearer

VERSION 4

Prompt: summarize the book for children and teenagers and ensure you break it into chapters using this format: CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nobody's born funny...(written on a new line)

Output:

CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nobody's born funny.
It just looks that way because we don't see all the practice behind it. Being funny is a skill, like drawing or skating — you build it over time, not something you're handed at birth.

CHAPTER TWO: Your Brain Was Built to Laugh
Your brain is wired to expect certain things, and it loves being pleasantly surprised. That surprise is what makes you laugh. Understanding this "surprise trick" is the secret behind almost every joke.

CHAPTER THREE: The Superpower of Observation

Funny people notice weird little details that everyone else walks right past. Training yourself to actually *notice* the world around you is one of the biggest comedy skills there is.

CHAPTER FOUR: Every Funny Person Is a Great Storyteller

A funny moment is really just a mini-story. If you build a little tension, add vivid details, and don't rush to the end, your stories (and jokes) will land way better.

CHAPTER FIVE: Timing — The Invisible Skill That Makes Humor Work

The exact same joke can bomb or kill depending on when you say it. A well-placed pause can make something ten times funnier. This is a skill you can practice, not something you either have or don't.

what changed in the prompt: Gave it a more precise instruction

What improved in the output: Followed the intended output format

What still failed: The output looks so ai generated

What would you try to improve: Make it look cleaner and more human like

VERSION 5

Prompt: summarize the book for children and teenagers and ensure you break it into chapters using this format: CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nobody's born funny...(written on a new line) Remove characters that make it look ai generated and make it sound more human like and natural

Output:

CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny

Nobody's really born funny. It just looks that way from the outside because you never see all the practice that happened behind the scenes. Being funny is something you learn, kind of like drawing or skateboarding, not something you're handed at birth.

CHAPTER TWO: Your Brain Was Built to Laugh

Your brain likes to guess what's coming next, and it gets a little kick when it's wrong in a good way. That surprise is basically what makes you laugh. Once you understand that trick, you start to see why jokes work in the first place.

CHAPTER THREE: The Superpower of Observation

Funny people just notice more. They catch little details that most people walk right past without thinking twice. Paying closer attention to the world around you turns out to be one of the biggest comedy skills there is.

CHAPTER FOUR: Every Funny Person Is a Great Storyteller

A joke is really just a tiny story. If you build a bit of tension, throw in some vivid details, and don't rush to the ending, both your stories and your jokes land a lot better.

CHAPTER FIVE: Timing, the Invisible Skill That Makes Humor Work

The same exact joke can flop or kill depending on when you say it. Even a short pause before the punchline can make it way funnier. Turns out timing is something you can actually get better at with practice.

what changed in the prompt : I gave it the right tone

What improved in the output: It looks cleaner and more human like

What still failed: Nothing, this looks fine

What would you try to improve: It is okay

Final Version:

summarize the book for children and teenagers and ensure you break it into chapters using this format: CHAPTER ONE: The Great Myth of Being Born Funny Nobody's born funny...(written on a new line)

Remove characters that make it look ai generated and make it sound more human like and natural